



DAILY EDITORIAL SUMMARY

08th May 2026

Topics to be covered:

- ✓ **Expanded Definition of Acid Attack Victim**
- ✓ **Preventing Fires and Fighting Fires**
- ✓ **Invasive Alien Species in India: Ecological Threats, Systemic Drivers, and the Need for Holistic Restoration**

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Topics

Expanded Definition of Acid Attack Victim

GS II: Mechanisms, Laws, Institutions and Bodies Constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections

Context:

Recently, the Supreme Court held that survivors of acid attacks, who were forced to consume acid and suffered internal injuries without any visible scarring, will be considered acid attack victims under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016.

Discrepancy in Treatment of Victims:

- ❖ **Case of Priya:** Acid was thrown on her face, leading to **visible disfigurement**.
 - She was **recognised as an acid attack victim** and received disability certificates and reservation benefits.
- ❖ **Case of Supriya:** She was **forced to drink acid**, causing severe burns to her throat, food pipe, and stomach.
 - Since **acid was not “thrown” externally**, authorities **denied her recognition and welfare benefits**.
 - The case reflected bureaucratic **adherence to the literal wording of the law** rather than its intended purpose.

Historical Legal Evolution (Pre-2013 to 2016):

- ❖ **Pre-2013:** There were **no specific provisions for acid attacks in the IPC**.
 - They were **registered under general sections** for causing **grievous hurt**.
- ❖ **2013 Amendment:** Following a long legal battle by **Laxmi Agarwal**, acid attacks **formally became a separate offence under IPC**.
- ❖ **2016 Act:** The **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016** recognised **21 types of disabilities**, including **acid attack victims**, allowing them access to government schemes and reservations.

Legal Gap in Section 2(zc) of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016:

- ❖ **Narrow Definition:** Schedule II, Section 2(zc) defined an **acid attack victim** as a person “**disfigured due to violent assaults by throwing of acid**.”
- ❖ **Exclusion of Internal Injuries:** Victims forced to ingest acid were excluded because they **lacked visible external disfigurement**.
 - The law focused on external scars while **ignoring equally severe internal injuries**.
- ❖ **Nature of Internal Harm:** **Acid ingestion** can **permanently damage the mouth, throat, oesophagus, stomach, and digestive system**.
 - **Survivors often face lifelong complications in eating, swallowing, and digestion.**

Constitutional Challenges Raised:

- ❖ **Article 14: Right to Equality**
 - **Under-Classification:** The petition argued that the law **arbitrarily differentiated between throwing acid and administering acid**. Both categories suffered **identical harm** and therefore formed a single class of victims.
 - **Lack of Rational Nexus:** The distinction had **no connection with the object of the law**, which was to support persons disabled by acid violence.

- ❖ **Article 21: Right to Life and Dignity**
 - **Denial of Welfare Support:** Exclusion from the statutory definition denied survivors access to disability certificates, compensation, and rehabilitation.
 - **Dignified Life:** The petition argued that access to medical care and support is essential for a dignified life for survivors suffering severe internal injuries.
- ❖ **Legal Inconsistency Highlighted**
 - **Conflict Between Criminal and Welfare Law:** Section 124 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2024 treats throwing acid and administering acid as the same offence.
 - **Arbitrary Distinction:** The petition argued it was legally incoherent for welfare law to distinguish between two forms of the same crime when criminal law did not.

Principle of Purposive Interpretation:

- ❖ **Meaning:** Purposive interpretation means interpreting a statute according to the intention of lawmakers rather than only its literal wording.
- ❖ **Application in this Case:** Since the RPwD Act is welfare legislation, the Court was urged to interpret it liberally to include all victims of acid violence.
 - The petition requested the phrase “throwing of acid” be read broadly as “use of acid.”

Key Points of the recent Supreme Court Judgment:

- ❖ **Inclusion of Ingestion:** Anyone forced to drink acid is now legally equal to those who have acid thrown on them.
- ❖ **Retrospective Effect:** The ruling applies retrospectively from 2016.
 - The government must identify and provide benefits to all such victims from the last 10 years who were previously ignored.
- ❖ **Concern Over Weak Deterrence:** The Supreme Court observed that existing punishments are not creating adequate deterrence against acid attacks and the need for harsher measures to effectively curb such crimes.
- ❖ **Reverse Burden of Proof:** The court suggested that in acid attack cases, the principle of “innocent until proven guilty” should be compromised, placing the burden on the accused to prove their innocence.
- ❖ **Seller Liability:** To create deterrence, the court suggested that if acid is easily available in the market despite regulations, the seller should be made a co-accused.

Concern Over Trial Pendency:

- ❖ **Rising Number of Cases:** The Court noted an alarming increase in acid attack incidents since 2013.
- ❖ **Backlog of Trials:** Uttar Pradesh reported the highest pendency with 198 cases.
 - West Bengal followed with 160 pending cases.
 - Gujarat recorded 114 pending cases.
 - Bihar reported 68 pending cases.
 - The Court termed delayed trials a “mockery of the system.”
- ❖ **States with Lower Pendency:**
 - Uttarakhand had 3 pending cases.
 - Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh together reported 5 pending cases.
- ❖ **Direction to High Courts:** In December last year, the Court directed Registrars General of all High Courts to submit details of pending acid attack trials in their jurisdictions.

Mains Practice

- Q. The expansion of the definition of ‘acid attack victim’ by the Supreme Court highlights the constant need for purposive interpretation of welfare legislations in India. Discuss the statement in light of the Right of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 and the prevailing judicial backlog in such cases. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

Preventing Fires and Fighting Fires

GS Paper III: Urban Fire Safety and Disaster Management

Context:

Recent fire tragedies in Delhi (Shahdara, Palam, Dwarka) have exposed serious gaps in urban fire safety, evacuation planning, electrical infrastructure, and enforcement of basic preventive measures.

The “Illusion of Security” and Safety Failures:

- ❖ **Electronic Locks:** In the Shahdara fire, the power cut disabled electronic locks, trapping residents inside.
 - The locks were not “fail-safe” and did not automatically open during emergencies.
- ❖ **Security Grilles:** Heavy iron grilles installed for theft prevention obstructed firefighter access and rescue operations.
- ❖ **Blocked Terrace Access:** Locked or blocked terrace access prevented residents from escaping upward during the fire.

Root Cause: MCBs and Electrical Negligence

- ❖ **Function of an MCB:** A Miniature Circuit Breaker (MCB) automatically cuts power when current exceeds safe levels, preventing overheating and fires.
 - Every electrical wire is designed to carry only a limited amount of current.
 - When too many appliances are connected or a fault occurs, excessive current flows through the wires, causing them to heat up.
 - The MCB detects this overload and “trips” by switching off the power supply before the wires become dangerously hot.
- ❖ **Unsafe Practices:** In many buildings, repeated tripping of an MCB is seen as an inconvenience rather than a warning sign.
 - Instead of reducing the electrical load or repairing faulty wiring, people often replace the existing MCB with a higher-capacity one.
- ❖ **Danger of Using Higher-Capacity MCBs:** A higher-capacity MCB delays or prevents power cut-off even when the wires are overheating. As a result:
 - Excessive current continues flowing through undersized wires.
 - The insulation around wires melts due to heat.
 - Sparks or short circuits occur.
 - Nearby combustible materials such as wooden panels, plastic conduits or furniture catch fire.
- ❖ **Hidden Internal Fires:** Compromised safety systems can cause fires to start inside walls before spreading across the building

Infrastructure and Systemic Challenges:

- ❖ **Ineffective Equipment:** Basic firefighting systems like hydraulic lifts, sprinklers and alarms often remain inadequate or non-functional.
- ❖ **Congested Urban Planning:** Narrow lanes and illegal constructions prevent fire engines from reaching accident sites quickly.
- ❖ **Illegal Mixed-Use Buildings:** Residential-commercial mixed-use buildings often operate without proper fire safety clearances.

Historical Patterns and Failure to Learn:

- ❖ **Uphaar Cinema fire:** One of Delhi’s most tragic fire disasters highlighting failures in emergency preparedness.
- ❖ **Surat coaching centre fire:** Several students died after locked terrace access prevented escape during the fire.

Way Forward:

- ❖ **Mandatory Building Codes:** The National Building Code (NBC) fire safety guidelines should be made legally enforceable.
- ❖ **Fail-Safe Electronic Locks:** Electronic locks should automatically unlock during power failures or fire emergencies.
- ❖ **Mandatory Electrical Audits:** Buildings older than 10 years should undergo compulsory electrical safety audits every three years.
- ❖ **Community Fire Drills:** Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) should coordinate with National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) for regular fire safety mock drills.

Mains Practice

- Q. The rapid urbanisation in India has morphed residential complexes into potential death traps during fire emergencies. Discuss the systemic flaws in urban planning and electrical safety protocols that exacerbate these hazards. Suggest measures based on the National Building Code. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

Invasive Alien Species in India: Ecological Threats, Systemic Drivers, and the Need for Holistic Restoration

GS Paper III: Environment

Context:

Across India, **campaigns against invasive alien species (IAS)** like *Prosopis juliflora*, *Lantana camara*, and *Senna spectabilis* are intensifying, but **experts argue that removing these species alone cannot restore ecosystems unless the deeper ecological disruptions that enabled their spread are addressed.**

About Invasive Alien Species (IAS):

- ❖ **Definition:** IAS are **non-native species** that **spread aggressively** and **outcompete native biodiversity**, causing ecological and economic damage.
- ❖ **“Unwanted Guest” Analogy:** IAS are like an **uninvited guest** who **gradually takes over the house and displaces the original owner.**
- ❖ **Historical Origins:** Many invasive species were **introduced intentionally for ornamental or afforestation purposes** during colonial rule.
 - Others arrived accidentally through **trade and imports** such as **PL-480 wheat imports from the USA.**
- ❖ **Difference between Alien and Invasive Species:**
 - **Alien Species:** Non-native species introduced from another region that are **generally non-harmful**, such as **Potato and Tomato.**
 - **Invasive Alien Species (IAS):** Alien species that **spread aggressively and harm native ecosystems**, such as *Lantana camara* and *Water Hyacinth (Eichhornia crassipes)*.

Major Invasive Alien Species (IAS) in India:

- ❖ **Lantana camara:** It was introduced during **British rule** as an **ornamental shrub.**
 - **It uses allelopathy:** A biological phenomenon in which a **plant releases chemicals that inhibit the germination, growth, or survival of nearby plants.**
 - **Rapidly regenerates** after cutting, making eradication difficult.
 - **Degrades forests, grasslands, and wildlife habitats through dense thicket formation.**

- ❖ **Prosopis juliflora (Vilayati Kikar):** Introduced for afforestation and greening arid regions of Rajasthan and Gujarat.
 - Extracts excessive groundwater, worsening **water stress conditions**.
 - **Replaces native grasses and alters ecosystem structure** in dryland regions.
 - **Reduces biodiversity and grazing potential.**
- ❖ **Water Hyacinth (Jal Kumbhi/Terror of Bengal):** Rapidly spreads across lakes, ponds, and rivers.
 - Blocks sunlight penetration and reduces dissolved oxygen levels (**Eutrophication**).
 - Harms fisheries and aquatic biodiversity.
 - Obstructs water transport and disrupts aquatic ecosystems.
- ❖ **Parthenium hysterophorus (Gajar Ghas):** Entered India through **imported wheat consignments**.
 - **Damages crops** and lowers agricultural productivity.
 - Causes **asthma, skin allergies, and respiratory disorders**.
 - **Invades grazing lands** and reduces fodder availability.

Ecological and Systemic Impacts of Invasive Species:

- ❖ **Biodiversity Loss:** IAS **outcompete native plants**, leading to decline of herbivores, affecting carnivores, and ultimately disrupting the entire food chain.
- ❖ **Altered Soil Chemistry:** Invasive species **modify nutrient cycles and soil conditions**, reducing the survival of native plants.
- ❖ **Increased Fire Risk:** Dry invasive vegetation **raises the intensity and frequency of forest fires**.
- ❖ **Water Stress:** Dense invasive species **increase evapotranspiration**, releasing large amounts of water vapour and rapidly depleting groundwater.
- ❖ **Aquatic Ecosystem Collapse:** Water Hyacinth **depletes dissolved oxygen**, threatening fisheries and aquatic biodiversity.

Root Causes of Ecosystem Vulnerability:

- ❖ **Climate Change:** Rising temperatures, erratic rainfall, and droughts weaken native species, while IAS exploit ecological gaps as opportunistic colonisers.
- ❖ **Unsustainable Agriculture:** Excessive urea and chemical use reduce soil microbial diversity and weaken soil resilience.
- ❖ **Habitat Fragmentation:** Roads, mining, and infrastructure create **fragmented forests** and **edge effects** favourable for invasive species like Lantana camara.
- ❖ **Wetland and River Modification:** Dams, sewage discharge, and **nutrient-rich polluted waters** create ideal conditions for Water Hyacinth (Eichhornia crassipes).

Limitations of Removal Approach:

- ❖ **Persistent Soil Seed Banks:** Invasive species like Lantana camara **leave behind dormant seeds in the soil** that **can survive for years** and **regenerate rapidly even after removal**.
- ❖ **Vacant Ecological Niches:** Removing invasive species without restoring soil, water, and biodiversity conditions **leaves ecosystems vulnerable to reinvasion**.
- ❖ **Irreversible Ecological Changes:** Altered climate, hydrology, and nutrient cycles may **prevent ecosystems from returning to their original natural state**.

Way Forward:

- ❖ **Holistic Ecological Restoration:** Restoration should simultaneously **revive soil health, hydrological cycles, and native biodiversity**.

- ❖ **Climate-resilient Afforestation:** Plantation drives must **prioritise native species adapted to heat waves, droughts, and changing climatic conditions.**
- ❖ **Community Participation:** The **Maldhari community** in the **Banni Grasslands** of **Gujarat** partnered with the forest department to **remove Prosopis juliflora** and **revive native Banni grasslands.**

Conclusion:

The long-term solution lies not merely in removing invasive species, but in **building resilient ecosystems capable of resisting future invasions.**

Mains Practice

- Q.** The eradication of Invasive Alien Species (IAS) alone is insufficient to halt ecological degradation in India. Discuss this statement in light of the compounding factors of climate change and unsustainable human practices. Suggest a comprehensive ecosystem-based restoration approach. (250 Words, 15 Marks)

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